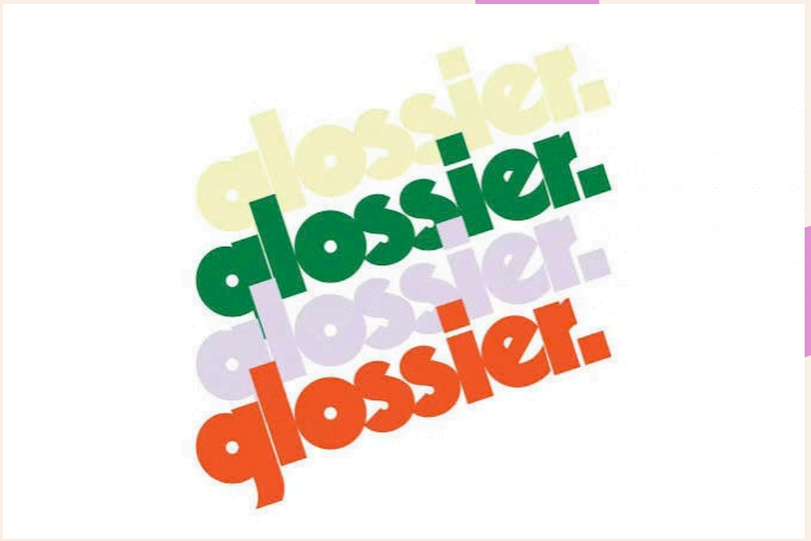
Glossier Strategy

Studio Shodwe

Building Strong, Memorable Brands



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Introduction

Glossier.



Question 1: History, background, and development

Born from a community

- (Owned Media)
- Founded by Emily Weiss after building Into The Gloss, a beauty blog with 1.5M monthly unique visitors
- ITG created two-way conversations around beauty routines, products, and experiences
- Glossier launched after the success of its community, rather than creating products first and searching for customers
- Philosophy: “Born from content, fueled by community”

Limited Owned Media

- Early Glossier relied relatively little on traditional advertising
- Nearly 80% of first-year sales came from owned & earned media
- This allowed Glossier to “earn” customers through community rather than primarily paying to acquire them

Creating a sharable “Cult” Brand (Earned Media)

- Glossier aimed to become more than a cosmetics company — a beauty lifestyle brand customers could identify with
- Built identity, belonging, and community, turning customers into active brand advocates
- Products and experiences were designed to encourage user-generated content and social sharing
- Signature Glossier pink, minimalist packaging, stickers, and pink pouches made the brand instantly recognizable online
- Customers voluntarily shared products, wore Glossier merchandise, and recommended the brand, generating earned media
- This customer-created content strengthened Glossier’s cult-like community and helped attract new customers

From community into Growth

Community Driven Growth

- Nearly 80% of first-year sales came from owned and earned media
- 25% of new customers came through peer-to-peer outreach
- Customers tagged @Glossier in 50,000+ Instagram posts in the second half of 2017
- Those posts generated a combined reach of 17M+

Rapid business Expansion

- Sales grew approximately 600% in 2017
- Expanded from 4 original products → 26 products
- Product prices ranged from approximately $12–$60
- By mid-2016, around 60,000 customers were on product waiting lists
- Opened its first New York pop-up store at 2026, bringing the online community into a physical space

$52 Million Serie-C (2018)

- Glossier's rapid growth attracted an oversubscribed $52M Series C investment, providing the capital to pursue its next stage of expansion.



How should Glossier deploy the 52M

Question 2: Funding priorities

Customer Acquisition & Retention

Organic/community growth was becoming harder to scale.

- Organic/community growth was becoming harder to scale
- Needed new customers while maintaining retention

Product & Technology Capabilities

Maintain investment for long-term growth

- Larger scale required stronger R&D and product-development capabilities
- Technology could connect discovery → community → shopping → sharing
- Nearly 50 technology employees, about 1/3 of the company

Distribution & Physical Expansion

- Expand beyond Glossier's DTC-only reach
- Give customers more opportunities to discover, test & purchase products
- Reach a large existing beauty-shopping audience
- more effective than building many Glossier-owned stores
- Glossier eventually entered Sephora in 2023, validating retail distribution as an important part of its later growth strategy.

question 3



Peer Sales Representatives Offer the Strongest Fit

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Recommendation: prioritize a controlled pilot of peer-to-peer sales representatives.

Why Glossier Should Choose Peer Sales Representatives
Glossier should prioritize peer sales representatives because personal recommendations fit its community-based approach. Existing customers can explain how they use the products and answer questions through relatable experiences. This approach could attract new buyers while giving loyal customers a more active role in the brand. However, representatives should disclose commissions so customers can judge recommendations fairly.

How Each Program Would Change Customer Relationships

- Peer sales representatives: Customers become advocates who help others discover products. This can strengthen participation and trust, although commissions may make recommendations feel less genuine.
- Influencer marketing: Customers connect with Glossier through creators they follow. This can expand awareness, but the relationship may depend more on the influencer than on Glossier itself.
- Paid advertising: Glossier reaches customers through targeted promotional messages. This increases exposure, but creates fewer opportunities for personal interaction and customer participation.
- Customer loyalty programs: Customers receive recognition and benefits for returning. This can strengthen retention, although heavy reliance on discounts may encourage loyalty to rewards rather than to the brand.

Pop-Ups Should Lead Physical Expansion

question4

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Why Glossier Should Prioritize Pop-Up Stores

Glossier should prioritize pop-up stores because they allow customers to try products in person while helping the company test local demand before committing to permanent locations. Direct online sales should remain the core channel, with successful pop-ups guiding future showroom openings. A limited Sephora pilot could follow if Glossier can maintain a consistent customer experience.

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How Each Option Would Change Customer Relationships



- **More showrooms**: Customers can test products and receive personalized advice from Glossier staff. This can deepen trust, but permanent locations require sufficient demand to justify their costs.
- **More pop-up stores:** Customers can discover Glossier locally and connect through events. These experiences can build excitement and belonging, although temporary locations limit ongoing access.
- **Wholesale through Sephora**: Customers gain convenient access and can compare Glossier with other brands. However, Sephora would manage much of the shopping experience, giving Glossier less direct contact with customers and less access to their feedback.

question 5

The Community Can Improve Every Part of the Marketing Mix



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Glossier’s Community Across the Marketing Mix
How can glossier best utilize its brand community

Glossier should treat its community as a source of customer insight and participation throughout the marketing mix.

- Product: Involve customers in identifying unmet needs and testing new products.
- Price: Research customers’ budgets and perceived value to guide pricing.
- Place: Use customer feedback and regional demand to choose pop-up and showroom locations.
- Promotion: Share real customer experiences and encourage recommendations with clear disclosure of paid incentives.

How the Approach Should Change as the Community Grows

With a smaller community, direct conversations can guide decisions and help customers feel personally involved. As the community grows exponentially, those conversations become harder to maintain, and its members develop more diverse needs.

Glossier should therefore supplement informal feedback with representative surveys, segmented testing panels, and regional community groups. It should also explain how customer input influences decisions. The community would remain central, but Glossier would need to measure whose voices it hears and ensure that quieter customers and new members also shape the brand.

Glossier's Advantage Depends on Trust and Product Performance

question 6

Sources of strength

- An existing beauty audience provides customer insight and a foundation for discovery.
- Direct relationships support faster feedback and a consistent shopping experience.
- A recognizable identity encourages emotional attachment and recommendations.

Potential weaknesses

- Competitors can imitate packaging and minimalist beauty messages.
- Dependence on social platforms creates exposure to algorithm changes.
- Rapid growth may reduce responsiveness and make customers feel overlooked.

Sustainability: the advantage can last if Glossier consistently turns customer insight into effective products. Visual identity alone offers limited protection.

Why?
Glossier's advantage can last because customer trust and an engaged community take time to build. Customer feedback can help Glossier develop products that better meet users' needs, encouraging repeat purchases and recommendations. Competitors can imitate its packaging and visual style more easily than they can reproduce these relationships.

Is “Best Friend” the Most Effective Relationship Model?

So, What Is The Best Freind Model?

- A relationship template where the brand acts like a “peer” not an authority
- A relational template is the kind of relationship a brand tries to have with its customers. "Best friends" means the brand acts like an equal who listens, is candid, shares values, and gives customers a sense of belonging.
- Customers are treated as experts.
- The company talks casually and honestly.
- Communication goes both ways. (Milky Jelly Cleanser)
- Loyalty comes from belonging.

Why?

- Customers may welcome personal communication, but they also need reliable products and honest advice. Friendship language can create expectations that a large company cannot consistently meet

Comparison to Other Brands

Brand As Authority

- **Expertise:** Experts tell you what to use
- **Voice:** Stiff, reads like a company writing and not like someone who actually cares about the product.
- **Direction:** The brand talks and the customer receives.
- **Loyalty:** "Ownership of a small piece of something amazing"

Is It the Most Effective Strategy? What Excites Us? What Worries Us?

Is It The Most Effective Strategy?

- The first year, approx 80% sales came from owned and earned media
- Peer-to-Peer outreach brought 25% of new customers
- In the second half of 2017, customers tagged @Glossier in over 50,000 Instagram posts, reaching more than 17 million people
- Emily notes 60% of women say a peer's recommendation is the top reason they try a new beauty product.

What Excites Us

- It's cheap and trusted: only 30% of brand impressions came from paid media, while 50% were earned.
- Customers feed product ideas back, and they act as channels for the brand.
- Customers feel like they belong, which Davis says is the point.

What Worries Us

- Hard to stay close as it grows: Hundreds of thousands of comments come in each week
- Customers are more varied now: They're no longer just bicoastal millennials
- Can feel exclusive: One customer called the brand "cliquish"
- Paid recommendations may make friendship feel like a sales tactic. Customers may also feel personally disappointed when Glossier ignores feedback or delivers poor service.

Question 8

How should Glossier position itself relative to competitors?

Positioning means deciding what you want customers to think of your brand compared with the alternatives**.**

Glossier should position itself as an approachable beauty brand that offers effective, easy-to-use products shaped by customer insights.

- **Target consumers:** Digitally active young adults who value simple routines, natural-looking makeup, and opportunities to participate in the brand.
- **Brand personality:** Friendly, inclusive, and knowledgeable, with honest communication about product benefits and limitations.
- **Marketing channels:** Keep direct e-commerce central. Use customer content and transparent peer recommendations for discovery, supported by selective paid advertising. Offer pop-ups and showrooms for product testing.
- **Against traditional beauty brands:** Emphasize customer participation and accessible guidance.
- **Against emerging DTC brands:** Demonstrate consistent product performance and show how customer feedback leads to meaningful improvements.

Glossier should focus on belonging, not assortment, convenience, or price. Against traditional beauty, the case says customers love a product without caring about its brand, like loving a mascara but not Maybelline. Glossier makes the brand the reason to buy.

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Have a Question?

We’re happy to discuss!



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Thank You!